

The Oracle

Guide 3 of 6

TL;DR

The Oracle is Theseus' question-answering surface. It does not run a free chat against a foundation model; it answers from the firm corpus and refuses — or warns — when the corpus is too thin. This guide explains what counts as a citation, what the hallucination warning actually means, and what to do with a low-confidence answer.

You will need

- A signed-in Codex session.
- A working corpus — at minimum a handful of uploads and a few accepted principles, otherwise the Oracle will mostly abstain.

This guide does NOT cover

- How claims get into the corpus — Guide 2.
- Currents opinions, which use a different (event-grounded) prompt path — Guide 4.
- Operator overrides of the Oracle's safety rails — Guide 6.

1 What the Oracle is

The Oracle lives at `/ (authed) /ask`. It accepts a question in natural language and returns:

- an answer, written in the firm's voice;
- a list of inline citations to claims, conclusions, principles, or uploads;
- a confidence band: `high`, `medium`, `low`, or `abstain`;
- a hallucination-risk badge when the answer contains material the citation chain does not unambiguously support.

It does not return: free-form essays not grounded in the corpus, opinions on outside events (that is Currents' job), or speculative projections (that is the forecasts portfolio's job).

[screenshot screenshots/03_oracle_answer.png not yet captured — An Oracle answer with inline citations, confidence band, and hallucination badge.]

2 What counts as a citation

A citation is a structured reference back to one of:

- **Claim** — an extracted statement from an upload. The most granular citation. Click-through lands on the source span.

- **Conclusion** — a synthesized firm position, possibly published as an article (`kind='ARTICLE'`) or as a reviewed conclusion (`kind='CONCLUSION'`). Citing one means the Oracle is leaning on a vetted firm output, not a raw extracted claim.
- **Principle** — a distilled, reusable position. The Oracle treats principles as soft constraints, not hard rules.
- **Upload** — a direct quote or paraphrase from an uploaded document, attached with offset and page number.

Every citation is clickable. If a citation does not click through, the Oracle has produced a broken reference — treat it as a hallucination warning even if no explicit badge is shown, and report it through **Critiques**.

3 Confidence bands

The Oracle assigns each answer a band based on the strength and breadth of the citation chain:

- **high** — the answer is supported by multiple independent citations, including at least one conclusion or principle.
- **medium** — the answer is supported by at least one citation that directly addresses the question.
- **low** — citations exist but only weakly support the answer. Treat as a starting point, not as a finished position.
- **abstain** — the corpus is too thin or off-topic to answer. The Oracle returns no answer text and explains which material it would have needed.

Abstention is the correct outcome for a sparse corpus. It is not a failure. The Oracle was deliberately designed to refuse where it would otherwise fabricate.

4 The hallucination warning

A hallucination badge appears when post-hoc verification finds the answer text contains a span that the cited sources do not unambiguously support. The badge does not necessarily mean the answer is wrong; it means the support is weaker than the prose makes it sound. Standard response:

1. Read the cited sources. Decide whether the unsupported span is a paraphrase that survives or an actual overreach.
2. If it is an overreach, rephrase the question to be narrower and re-ask. The Oracle's narrower answer is usually correct.
3. If you find the Oracle consistently overreaching on a topic, log a critique — the critiques pipeline feeds back into prompt and policy tuning.

5 What to do with low-confidence answers

Low confidence does not mean “probably wrong.” It means “the corpus will not let me commit to a sharper answer.” Useful responses:

- **Add corpus.** Upload one or two documents that directly address the question. Re-ask. The same question with denser material usually moves up a band.
- **Narrow the question.** A low-confidence answer to a broad question often becomes a high-confidence answer to a more specific sub-question.

- **Promote a principle.** If the topic recurs and the firm has a working position, draft and accept a principle (Guide 2). The Oracle will start citing it.
- **Accept abstention.** For genuinely outside-corpus questions, the right answer is “the firm does not have a position on this” — the Oracle will say so.

6 What the Oracle will not do

- It will not answer from general world knowledge alone. If the corpus does not contain relevant material, it abstains.
- It will not generate predictions, market opinions, or trade suggestions. Those routes are gated behind the operator confirmation flow described in Guide 5.
- It will not assert a firm position that contradicts an accepted principle without an explicit flag in the answer signalling the conflict.
- It will not surface private uploads in answers visible to readers outside the firm.

7 Where the docs are

- `docs/methods/MQS_Specification.md` — citation contract.
- `docs/security/Threat_Model.md` — what the Oracle is and is not allowed to reveal.
- `docs/operator/public_surfacing.md` — which corpus rows are eligible to back a publicly visible answer.

Where to read next

Continue with [Guide 4 — Currents](#) for the firm’s outward-facing live commentary surface, which uses a related but distinct citation contract.